Dalia Hatuqa and Nour Samaha, two dear friends and talented colleagues, probably heard every anecdote in this book over three years of meals and phone calls and WhatsApp conversations. They stayed interested to the end, or at least did a flawless job of pretending.

My dog Mila, a two-year-old Saluki mix, was a much-needed distraction, a reason to drag myself away from the computer. She also tried to type a few paragraphs, though sadly her contributions did not survive the editing process.

This book is dedicated to my late maternal grandmother, Lillian Goldston, whose offhanded comment about a Jerusalem garbageman planted a seed decades ago. She embodied everything that this agnostic and assimilated journalist finds powerful about the Jewish tradition: a deep sense of humanism, a critical mind, and a willingness to ask questions and challenge settled ideas. I hope she would have been proud, though I suspect she would also have some detailed criticism.

Finally, I met Harriet Salem just before this project began, and for three years she gave me her intellect, her support, and her love. The book made it out the other end; we didn’t. But I couldn’t have finished it without her.